France’s request we sent several AWACS planes and fighter escorts to help keep tabs on Libyan aircraft.

At summer’s end, the fighting in Lebanon between rival Christian, Muslim, and Druse militias grew heavier, putting Lebanon’s fragile truce and everything we’d been working for there in jeopardy. The civil war spread rapidly, threatening the stability of the Gemayel government and making it uncertain how Israel and Syria would react. Soon, what had been chaos in Beirut became anarchy and then more tragedy. Syrian forces, Iranian Shiite Muslims, and radical members of the PLO began taking sides in the civil war, and fighting expanded; Druse and Muslim snipers started attacking the members of the multinational force as they patrolled Beirut, then began attacking the Beirut airport compound where our marines were housed, killing several of them.

Here are portions of several entries pertaining to the worsening crisis in Lebanon from my diary of September 1983:

> *Sept. 6*
>
> We lost two more Marines last night in Beirut. The civil war is running wild and could result in the collapse of the Gemayel govt. and then stuff would hit the fan. I called the parents of the two Marines—not easy.
>
> *Sept. 7*
>
> More on Lebanon. We have to show the flag for those Marines. I can’t get the idea out of my head that some F-14’s off the *Eisenhower* coming in at about 200 feet over the Marines and blowing hell out of a couple of artillery emplacements would be a tonic for the Marines and at the same time would deliver a message to these gun happy Middle East terrorists.
>
> *Sept. 8*